

Fig. 1.4. Eugénie von Tunzelmann, Kip, and Oliver James.

And the end product, the visualizations in *Interstellar*, are amazing! And scientifically accurate.

You cannot imagine how ecstatic I was when Oliver sent me his initial film clips. For the first time ever—and before any other scientist—I saw in ultrahigh definition what a fast-spinning black hole looks like. What it does, visually, to its environment.

Matthew McConaughey, Anne Hathaway, Michael Caine, Jessica Chastain

On July 18, two weeks before filming was to begin, I received an e-mail from Matthew McConaughey, who plays Cooper: “per Interstellar,” he wrote, “I’d like to ask you some questions and . . . If you are around L.A. area, in person is preferable. Lemme know please, thanks, in process, mcConaughey.”

We met six days later, in a suite at L’Hermitage, a boutique hotel in Beverly Hills. He was ensconced there, struggling to wrap his head around the role of Cooper and the science of *Interstellar*.

When I arrived, he opened the door dressed in shorts and a tank top, barefooted and thin from having just filmed *Dallas Buyers’ Club* (for